British India in which Muslims were a majority was Bangladesh (the Land of Bengal). The Bangladesh that Fazlul Haq had in mind would, moreover, have included all of India's West Bengal and Calcutta, as well as what was to become East Pakistan.

Jinnah was brilliantly realistic, however, and he knew that asking for *two* independent Muslim nation-states might make the creation of Pakistan impossible. He himself was then sixty-four and physically frail, and it was no easy matter to convince not only the British, but the Indian National Congress, of the seriousness of the Muslim League's Lahore Resolution, dismissed by Congress leaders—and some British officials—as "a bargaining point," if not "the product of a diseased mentality." Though partition stripped Pakistan of the eastern half of Punjab and the western half of Bengal, including Calcutta, he therefore accepted the "moth-eaten" pieces that Mountbatten offered him.

The fragmented nation-state, split into two mutually remote wings, never really worked, however, and when Jinnah paid his first, brief, and only visit to Dhaka as Pakistan's Great Leader, he announced that West Pakistan's Urdu, rather than East Pakistan's Bengali, was to be Pakistan's sole national language. The millions of Bengalis who heard this speech needed no further evidence of their intolerably subordinate status to West Pakistan. Though they were all, indeed, Muslims, the primary bond that united them was their mother-tongue, not their religious faith. The richness and poetry of Bengali, the language of Rabindranath Tagore, was the cultural glue that made their "Golden Bengal" a nation. So in December 1970, in the wake of that year's devastating cyclone, every Bengali who voted cast his vote for Sheikh Mujibur Rahman's Awami (People's) League, whose Six Points called for the virtual independence of East Pakistan's Bangladesh from West Pakistan's military junta.

Most West Pakistanis voted for Zulfi Bhutto's Pakistan People's Party, but there were ten million fewer voters in the West than in the East, so the Awami League won 160 seats, all but two of the contests in the East, while the PPP could claim only 81 seats in the West. Mujibur Rahman should, therefore, have become Pakistan's newly elected prime minister the very day all those votes were finally counted early in 1971. Neither Zulfi Bhutto nor Yahya Khan could accept the idea of turning their entire country over to Bengalis, however, whose language neither of them spoke, and whose small, dark-skinned physiques neither of them believed worthy specimens of Pakistani stature. In many ways, West Pakistanis treated their eastern "colony" as arrogantly as British sahibs